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Editorial | Making the downtown Santa Cruz library safe

Homeless in front of the Santa Cruz Public Library, Friday, October 10, 2025. Santa Cruz Public Library reports an opening up about the criminal activity occurring in the building. (Shmuel Thaler - Santa Cruz Sentinel)

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The Oct. 3 Sentinel story on complaints by workers in the Santa Cruz public library system about harassment including verbal and physical assaults at their workplace downtown, deserves a firm response from library administrators including the city itself.

Sentinel reporter Ari Steiger interviewed two employees who both requested anonymity to avoid potential retaliation from their employer (and probably social media backlash). Both said they want to see the city of Santa Cruz do more to support workers when incidents of assault occur.

The employees told the reporter that library workers don't want to fuel more antipathy toward homeless people, but they want more security and more staff training on trauma-informed, public amenities including bathrooms, might help lessen the environment. Still, they said, the library is not equipped to provide social services, adding "Why aren't the city meet in these services and meet in the library rather than investing in nothing?"

One said, "I can't tell you how many times I've had someone say they don't bring their kids to the library because it's not a welcoming place to be."

The workers mentioned that the unsafe working environment also leads to high turnover and short staffing in the library system, which further exacerbates safety issues. They asked at a minimum that employees be allowed to go home with pay if, or apparently when, they are assaulted on the job.

The Santa Cruz City-County Library System operates under the authority of the Library Joint Powers Authority, which is made up of the cities and counties of Santa Cruz and Scotts Valley. Joint Powers Agreement, library employees are employees of the city of Santa Cruz and are part of the city's civil service system.

In a statement to the Sentinel earlier this month, a city spokesperson acknowledged "working in the public sector today can sometimes involve challenging interactions" and that the city "takes the safety and security of our employees very seriously and is committed to support" and "to continuously improving safety practices to ensure workers feel supported and safe."

This is hardly a new issue. The Church Street library has, for decades, been a gathering place for people facing — and not to cast shame on individuals living on the streets or suffering from mental illness — challenges. The Church Street library has been a respite for many, a place to use the bathrooms, or to scroll Internet sites on library computers, or even to find a quiet place where they won't be hassled. Some, however, have abused the privileges.

The Sentinel report noted that the Downtown Branch has probably contracted security guards more than any other branch in the system. Employees said they want to see more staff training, they are often the first to respond to unruly or violent people, which their online de-escalation trainings does not prepare them for.

Since the Sentinel report, the city responded by considering establishing paid leave for employees who suffer traumatic incidents, along with more guidance for reporting and responding to violent and abusive incidents, among other efforts to ensure staff safety. While none of this is publicly confirmed, unsafe incidents involve workers, city representatives likely have been in contact with the employees' bosses and perhaps have conducted interviews. A few employees who came forward, albeit anonymously, both are SEIU Local 521 members.

What can be done? Santa Cruz police are already stretched thin responding to situations that often involve people suffering from mental illness or substance abuse. Another answer is more trained security guards and a better response system.

Of course all this might be academic in a couple of years when the new downtown library is built (pending of the site recently started). That project, built in downtown Santa Cruz at Cathcart, Cedar and Lincoln streets, will include a 100-square-foot of library space, 124 affordable housing units, a child-care center and a parking garage.

The new library plus social not seem conclusive to becoming a shelter for people looking to get off the streets, but brings with it its own controversies, which have been detailed for years in the Sentinel.

The current library site will probably become a permanent home to the Farmers market among other uses including housing, city offices and a civic plaza. But with homeless services funding facing severe financial challenges, it's going to take teamwork and creativity to keep these sites a haven for the greater community.

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